Revue d'études benthamiennes

23 | 2023
Utilitarianism and Socialism

Dr John Conolly: An Owenite in Disguise?

The Combined Influence of Utilitarianism and Utopian Socialism on the Implementation of Lunacy Reform at Hanwell Asylum (1839-1852)

John Conolly: Une figure méconnue de l'owénisme? L'influence conjointe de l'utilitarisme et du socialisme utopique sur la mise en œuvre de la réforme asilaire à Hanwell (1839-1852)

Laurence Dubois

OpenEdition Journals

Electronic version
URL: https://journals.openedition.org/etudes-benthamiennes/10538
DOI: 10.4000/etudes-benthamiennes.10538
ISSN: 1760-7507

Publisher
Centre Bentham

Electronic reference
Laurence Dubois, "Dr John Conolly: An Owenite in Disguise? ", *Revue d'études benthamiennes* [Online], 23 | 2023, Online since 20 January 2023, connection on 13 March 2023. URL: http://journals.openedition.org/etudes-benthamiennes/10538 ; DOI: https://doi.org/10.4000/etudes-benthamiennes.10538

This text was automatically generated on 13 March 2023.

All rights reserved

Dr John Conolly: An Owenite in Disguise?

The Combined Influence of Utilitarianism and Utopian Socialism on the Implementation of Lunacy Reform at Hanwell Asylum (1839-1852)

John Conolly: Une figure méconnue de l'owénisme? L'influence conjointe de l'utilitarisme et du socialisme utopique sur la mise en œuvre de la réforme asilaire à Hanwell (1839-1852)

Laurence Dubois

1 When one thinks about a potential link between utilitarianism and lunacy reform in nineteenth-century Britain, the element that spontaneously comes to mind is the connection between Bentham's panopticon and the architectural conception of lunatic asylums. But even though, as Anne Brunon-Ernst puts it, "Bentham's panopticon projects were widely circulated in penal reformist circles and contributed to the debate on how to build an efficient penal system",[1] its influence on asylum architecture was actually marginal.

A Bird's Eye View of the Hanwell Asylum in 1843

Source: *The Illustrated London News*
Copyright: Illustrated London News Ltd/Mary Evans.

2 The real connection between utilitarianism and lunacy reform is to be found much more clearly in the general context and conception of the "New" Poor Law. Jeremy Bentham's ideas resonated with reformers in general, regardless of party. For instance, Bentham was deeply involved in devising the "Poor Law Amendment Act" (1834) – even though he died in 1832, before the actual implementation of the system. It was precisely thanks to his support that Edwin Chadwick – Bentham's private secretary – was appointed Assistant Poor Law Commissioner in 1832, and later as head of the Poor Law Commission, where he defended utilitarian values, and especially the ideal of general happiness as being superior to individual happiness. Bentham's postulate is that the search for pleasure and the desire to escape suffering are the motives for action of every rational being, and that the sum of all individual happiness must result in the greatest possible happiness for the greatest number. But if all action is automatically and inherently based on a selfish desire, then how can we instil in everyone a moral sense and altruism sufficiently developed so that everyone feels concerned about the happiness of the greatest number? It is on this point that the opinions of utilitarians themselves diverge, and that two schools of thought emerged. For some, who could be described as supporters of a "natural Benthamism", self-interest and freedom of personal action are to be privileged and will inevitably lead to "a natural harmony of interests". For others, on the other hand, all the obstacles that man must overcome alone are too great to hope for a truly free action that would lead to happiness, and this fully justifies the role of the State, which must ensure to each one the most favourable conditions possible for the realisation of their happiness. In this context of "artificial harmony of interests", the State ensures a role of protection and guardianship, to guide the citizen on the path to autonomy.[2]

3 The basic assumptions of utilitarianism mentioned above, especially the notion of an "artificial harmony of interests", were among the founding principles of the Poor Law reform of 1834. To examine the implementation of lunacy reform and its connection to utilitarian principles, this paper will carry out a case study of Hanwell Asylum, which is both a symbol of Victorian asylums in general and an exemplification of the intricate relationship that existed between institutions such as prisons, workhouses and lunatic

asylums, all of them being part of the same local network of social control and/or assistance to the most deprived members of the community.

4 Hanwell Asylum was the first public asylum for the pauper lunatics living in the County of Middlesex. It opened its doors in 1831, in the South-West suburbs of London. In the late 1830s, more than 1,000 patients lived on the premises, making it the largest psychiatric institution in the country. The treatment applied there was based on the principle of "no restraint" or "non-restraint", a method that aimed at giving freedom of movement to all patients. Its originality from a medical point of view was reinforced by its social and, indeed, political dimension, well beyond a strictly therapeutical field. From the year 1839 onwards, when Dr. John Connolly was appointed medical superintendent of the institution, the asylum was governed with the avowed aim to help male and female patients alike to receive proper instruction within the asylum school, which remained highly controversial and constantly threatened with closure. Conolly was well-known for his commitment to the cause of popular education, as a member of the Society for the Diffusion of Useful Knowledge, as well as for his support of the Chartist movement. He thus viewed education as a central element, going far beyond a mere distraction for the insane and truly constituting a tool for social insertion and a means of emancipation for the lower classes. His views on education were similar to a utopian socialist (or Owenite) conception of schooling, and Hanwell's instructional amenities were a faithful replica of the New Lanark School[3] founded in the early nineteenth century. Besides, Robert Owen (1771-1858) – now considered one of the founding fathers of British socialism[4] came to Hanwell Asylum and visited John Conolly soon after he was appointed superintendent there, during the spring of 1839.

5 In this paper I will first demonstrate that lunacy reform has to be put into perspective as part of the wider social reform movement in Victorian Britain, itself largely shaped by Bentham's thought. Conolly's project at Hanwell Asylum will then be analysed as the result of a medical, but also political and social ambition. The last part will be dedicated to a presentation of "no restraint" as a movement situated at the crossroads of multiple influences and networks, especially utilitarianism and Owenism.

Lunacy Reform as part of a wider social reform movement

6 Camilla Haw and Graeme Yorston have provided a remarkably synthetic, yet relatively comprehensive overview of the state of historical research on English asylums in the 19th century:

> Jones[5] viewed the process as one of gradual reform and improvement, and Foucault[6] as a means of social control and repression. Scull[7] argued that ambitious but undervalued mad-doctors rebranded social deviance into mental illness in order to justify the creation of asylums, which they could then control. Smith[8] viewed asylums as existing in a complex network of care providers for the insane, and Bartlett[9] thought that county asylums were firmly rooted within the administrative framework of Poor Law provision.[10]

7 That lunacy reform was part of a wider social movement, as analysed by Peter Bartlett[11], is hardly debatable. The first parliamentary enquiry concerning mental illness and its treatment was launched in 1807 and a new one was organised in 1815, more complete and with a more pragmatical view. Its mission was to control and

examine the living conditions in asylums and madhouses, and to make various suggestions on how to improve the care of the insane, whether it be in public or private institutions. Two years later, the results of the investigation were published in a very long and detailed parliamentary report (600 pages) that clearly mentioned the "appalling degradation, inhuman treatment and neglect of pauper lunatics in public and private institutions".[12] According to the report, mental illness was rapidly becoming a central public health issue in Britain and should be treated as such and taken seriously. The rate of mental illness was constantly growing and in 1815 it accounted for 2.26 cases out of 10,000 for the whole population, which was deemed preoccupying. In 1844, this rate actually reached 12.66 out of 10,000, i.e. 6 times more than in 1815.[13] It would be difficult to explain thoroughly and with absolute certainty why there was such an increase in mental illness in the 19th century and this remains a puzzling question. A few factors may still be of interest to account for this phenomenon. This could have been linked first to a shift in values, making the Victorian society less tolerant to individual behaviours and more normative. This explanation, attractive as it may be, is not entirely convincing though, as asylums' records show that the reasons why people were sent to asylums in the Victorian era did not differ radically from what happened before, and admissions to asylums were often based on quite rational criteria (self-destructive behaviour, aggressive behaviour on the street, attempted murder, delusional speech, dementia). Another factor could have been the detrimental effects of the new modes of production on people's physical and mental health, in a society that had been radically transformed by the industrial revolution and in which competition and hard work were essential: working in a factory for more than fourteen hours a day was logically likely to affect workers' health and could lead them to various forms of self-destructive behaviour such as alcoholism. There was indeed great concern among alienists concerning the influence of what they called "circumstances" on their patients' health. As three quarters of the population suffering from mental illness were poor, this factor in the increase of madness in the 19th century should not be underestimated and clearly placed this phenomenon as a central issue for the authorities in charge of poor relief. Urbanisation and industrialisation also contributed to a social "need to segregate a group of people unable to cope for themselves in such an organized world".[14] Trevor Turner rightly points out that "the mopish villagers of seventeenth-century England could not be expected to deal with the regulated working hours of the nineteenth-century factories".[15] This explanation is quite convincing and relevant in the sense that it rightly considers that the more demanding a society is, the more difficult it becomes for people who are not energetic, competitive or healthy enough to survive under such social pressure.

8 As mental illness became more and more central in public health concerns and policies, a new parliamentary inquiry was set up in 1827, with a young and recently-elected MP who was soon to become a prominent figure in British politics: Lord Ashley (later Lord Shaftesbury).[16] The report was published in June 1827[17] and paved the way for a series of Acts of Parliament that reorganised the whole system and enabled Britain to enter a new age of therapeutic optimism and reconsideration of the way people should be treated and supported when they suffered from mental illness. It was also part of a more global reconsideration and reshaping of how to organize and rationalize poor relief. Following the specific legislation established after 1827, that defined how the mentally ill should be taken care of, eight new public asylums were built between 1828

and 1842 – which meant that there were now sixteen public institutions in England. But one may wonder why sending people to an asylum was seen as the only option available to cure the mentally ill or at least to take care of them. If we do consider that the County Asylums Acts were clearly embedded in the general legal context of the Poor Law, especially after it was amended in 1834, this choice then becomes quite logical and easily understandable. The law strictly favoured indoor relief over outdoor relief, meaning that if you were a pauper and wanted to be financially helped you had to go to the workhouse. Even though the mentally ill were not supposed to be officially part of this new scheme, as three quarters of them belonged to the lower classes the orientation that was given by the authorities concerning the assistance that was offered to them still had to remain compatible with the general principles of the New Poor Law.

9 From a purely therapeutic point of view, the promotion of the asylum was based on the idea that isolation was an integral component of the treatment. This notion of isolation as a means to cure mental illness was recognised as deeply efficient by all English and French alienists[18] at the time, and concretely meant that people should be placed in institutions where they would be deliberately isolated from their familiar background, i.e., their family and ordinary social environment, with the idea that this was the only way to enable them to regain energy and peace of mind. Thus, the intention was not primarily to exclude people from society but more to offer them a specific place in which they could be sheltered from external aggressions and would recover, an "asylum" in the basic and true sense of the term, "a Refuge from distress; an Asylum, not in name but in deed and in truth" as Robert Gardiner Hill put it.[19]

10 As asylums were now conceived as a genuine therapeutic tool (even though the reality could sometimes be less glorious than the original intentions), a reputation gradually emerged throughout the century of Britain as a progressive country in terms of patients' rights and as the centre of lunacy reform in the world. Elaine Showalter confirms that "from the 1830s to about 1870, experiment in the humane management of madness put English psychiatry in the avant-garde of Western medical practice and made English lunatic asylums a mecca for doctors and social investigators from all over the world".[20]

11 One should certainly keep in mind the fact that lunacy reform was deeply embedded in a general trend of reforms in Britain at the time and corresponded to a global conception of society as a whole. As Kathleen Jones explains:

> Lunacy reform was not an isolated movement. It was connected with the other reforms of the nineteenth century – reforms of the penal law, of factory law, new developments in education and public health. Like these other movements, it sprang from a conception of the community's responsibility for the well-being of its members, and revealed a new spirit of humanity in public life. The insane were in fact the first of the handicapped classes to receive legislative protection.[21]

12 Although the asylum officially became the preferred solution for the care of the insane, it seems that the number of patients housed in workhouses in 1844 was in fact greater than the number of residents in asylums: 3,579 insane persons were in public asylums, as opposed to 4,080 in workhouses, with the remainder divided between private asylums (2,559) and 'care' at home, most often provided by their family and friends (3,940).[22] Patients were usually kept in the workhouse in order to save money, since "the cost of keeping an insane person in the asylum was always appreciably larger than looking after the same individual in the workhouse",[23] and sending people to a lunatic

asylum was in fact "the most expensive option open to poor law authorities".[24] Theoretically, however, the mentally ill were not supposed to be cared for in workhouses. Indeed, the denial of outdoor relief to able-bodied paupers, one of the basic principles of the law, did not apply to the sick, nor to the mentally retarded, who were expressly excepted from the prohibitory order".[25] For this category of population, indoor relief should in principle remain an option, and if it was not possible for them to stay at home, it was recommended that they be "accommodated in separate buildings away from the punitive establishment for the able-bodied[...]"[26] Article 27 of the Act provided that aid might be granted to "any adult person who shall from old age or infirmity of body be wholly unable to work, without requiring that such person shall reside in any workhouse".[27] As far as mentally ill people were concerned, article 45 clearly stated the following principle:

> Nothing in this Act contained shall authorize the detention in any workhouse of any dangerous lunatic, insane person, or idiot, for any longer period than fourteen days; and every person willfully detaining in any workhouse any such lunatic, insane person, or idiot, for more than fourteen days, shall be deemed guilty of a misdemeanour [...].[28]

13 But this legal framework did not radically improve the situation for lunatics, who were frequently treated as ordinary, sane paupers with the lack of proper treatment that resulted from it.

Conolly's project at Hanwell Asylum: a medical, political and social ambition

14 The notion of "moral treatment" is in some way a reference to all "therapeutic efforts which [affect] the patient's psychology".[29] Scottish alienist William Alexander Francis Browne underlines that "there is a fallacy in conceiving that Moral Treatment consists in being kind and humane to the insane. It is this, and a great deal more than this".[30] He defines moral treatment (or "moral management") as "every mode by which the mind is influenced through the mind itself; in contradistinction to medical treatment, in which the mind is acted upon remotely by material agents, and through the body".[31] There are still elements in the application of moral management that do affect the body as it tends to focus on improving the living conditions of patients and their comfort on a daily basis, perhaps even more than on the idea of a fruitful and therapeutic dialogue between the patient and his doctor:

> They [the reformers] were inspired simply by the conviction that brutal coercive measures were not conducive to curing madness, but only reduced human beings to beasts. The humane treatment of lunatics [...] would help these unfortunates reaffirm their humanity. Where asylum directors subscribed to such beliefs, strait jackets, chains, straw bedding, sparse diet, purgatives, [...] and freezing showers gave way as fully as possible to organized activities, decent food, proper beds, patience, kindness, and cheerfulness, in the hope of transforming inmates into orderly, cooperative, and once again rational citizens.[32]

15 According to Vieda Skultans, what seems to be essential in moral management is the will to re-establish or reinforce the control that any individual can have over himself and his actions ("self control"). Skultans sees this as part of a pattern of values characteristic of the Victorian era and popularised by an author such as Samuel Smiles.[33] Moral treatment is indeed based on a fundamental desire to "encourage autonomy",[34]

and not to enslave patients; it is "simultaneously a triumph of humanism and of therapy, a recognition that kindness, reason, and tactful manipulation [are] more effective in dealing with the inmates of an asylum than [are] fear, brutal coercion and restraint, and medical therapy".[35] It is also systematically associated to what Lord Ashley called the non-coercion system ,[36] another term for "non-restraint" or "no restraint": "by this term is technically meant the non-use of mechanical restraint of the limbs by the strait waistcoat, leg-locks, etc.[...]".[37]

16 What makes Hanwell Asylum so unique and at the same time so typical in the Victorian psychiatric landscape is the fact that it remained a benchmark in the treatment of the insane for nearly thirty years, and served as a model for many other institutions, particularly in England.[38] If non-restraint was actually seen as a controversial form of treatment in the 1830s and remained difficult to impose upon a large number of institutions (for safety reasons among others), the fact that it proved successful at Hanwell, the largest asylum in the country, represented a genuine revolution for British alienists and radically changed the paradigm for the treatment of the insane. Non-restraint then rapidly became the norm, a sort of psychiatric orthodoxy recognised all over the country. The evidence lies in the fact that in the middle of the 1840s, only 5 asylums in England applied a policy of non-restraint for their inmates. From 1854 onwards, 27 out of the 30 public asylums in the kingdom had adopted this system, and 9 out of the 14 private madhouses were also part of it.[39] Two years later, only one public asylum remained that had not turned to non-restraint and moral management.[40] The success of the system at Hanwell Asylum is both Conolly's and the Justices of the Peace's achievement in supporting non-restraint as a gesture towards the poor and the insane. Akihito Suzuki proposes a properly political reading of the action taken in Hanwell; he believes that "the role of the county magistrates of Middlesex was as vital as that of the medical head",[41] and that non-restraint is part of an overall reform of asylum management, entirely "initiated, planned and executed by the magistrates".[42] According to him, what was at stake here was the fact that they wanted to find their own place in relation to the central government, in a form of confrontation and competition with the government, both on the issue of asylums and on that of prison reform,[43] and to demonstrate that local authorities were as competent as central authorities, if not more so. In this context, magistrates presented themselves as "agents of modernization and allies of the reformers".[44] At Hanwell, two magistrates played a leading role in the implementation of the non-restraint policy: John Adams and Charles Augustus Tulk, who, although of different political persuasions – one was a Tory, the other a Whig – agreed on the measures to be taken to reform the asylum. John Adams, "a sergeant-at-law and the chairman of the magistrates from 1839 to 1844",[45] was actively supportive of Conolly: it was on his initiative that Conolly visited Robert Gardiner Hill at Lincoln Asylum – a pioneering institution – before he took up his post to see how the system worked on the ground, and he gave him daily advice and encouragement. It is said that John Conolly, in his early days, wrote him up to three letters a day, in the greatest secrecy.[46] Adams also published more than twenty articles in favour of non-restraint in *The Lancet* (under the pseudonym "A Looker-On").[47] He was perfectly aware of the support he was giving, and even stated privately that "Dr. Conolly had much to contend against in the committee, and that if it were not for him, [...] [he] would not be able to go on[...]".[48]

17 Charles Augustus Tulk, on the other hand, was more discreet; he seemed to be less present in the daily life of the asylum or at Conolly's side, but he still provided him with valuable institutional support, and was undeniably a strong ally. Indeed, Charles Augustus Tulk was a former Whig MP, "liberal in his religious views" and very close to Joseph Hume, "the radical People' s MP".[49] He was president of the Swedenborg Society[50] and patron of the poet William Blake,[51] so he must be considered as an important figure, not just locally.

18 The role played by the magistrates, in particular Adams and Tulk, cannot be underestimated, and Akihito Suzuki's analysis is highly relevant in that it sheds light on Hanwell's experience in a way that takes the general context into account and demonstrates the extent to which it would be meaningless to consider it from a strictly therapeutic point of view or as the work of a single man. However, to infer than Conolly is a "mere cog of a huge bureaucratic machine"[52] , as Suzuki does, seems difficult to justify. To see Conolly as a sort of pawn, manipulated by the magistrates, is to forget that Conolly was also strongly politically committed, as a supporter of the Chartists and of popular education, that he was an Owenite sympathiser, the former mayor of Stratford and a lifelong participant in the public sphere.

19 His involvement in education for his male and female patients at Hanwell is one of the best illustrations of his personal convictions, sometimes expressed against the magistrates ruling the asylum, as they had some reluctance to invest in the education of these poor people who were the majority of the asylum's patients. This was in line with the classic mindset of the authorities responsible for implementing the Poor Law, who were "frequently hostile to the idea of educating paupers" .[53] The education of the poor was indeed a controversial issue in the nineteenth century, and "by no means everyone was convinced either that the working class should be educated or that government should have a hand in the process".[54] It was not uncommon to think, then, that if the poor were to be satisfied with their lot, it was necessary to keep them in ignorance, as Paul Sangster points out:

> Education, which shows that there is something better than that which one has, creates dissatisfaction and it takes discontent to bring change. Uneducated and without means of knowing how to care for themselves or how to improve their environment, the lower classes [fall] into apathy and indifference to the existing conditions.[55]

20 This is not to say that John Conolly's motivations were not genuinely therapeutic, for he saw the benefits of education as a valuable adjunct to treatment. However, his commitment was not without a certain political and social significance, and it was probably in this respect that he came up against the institution's administrators. He could not fail to be aware that poverty, as much as insanity, was an obstacle to education and as a former active member of the "Society for the Diffusion of Useful Knowledge", he undoubtedly adhered to this ideal of "salvation through science" .[56] It is also known that for Chartists, especially those who identified with the so-called 'moral force' movement, education was an essential element in a "programme which naturally favoured any extension of educational opportunity to members of the working-class".[57] For Conolly, the relationship between the democratisation of education and the extension of suffrage was crystal clear:

> More and more man's intellect becomes cultivated, and political rights become more and more generally and equally imparted to all classes, to which more and more comforts have gradually become familiar. This seems to be the point in which

> we may now survey the most advanced communities. Day by day their political rights are enlarging: if their knowledge stops short, these rights will be but instruments of mischief; with knowledge, they will be the means of assuring every blessing [...][58]

21 In promoting education at Hanwell, Dr Conolly was obviously fulfilling his duties as an alienist, concerned with improving the mental state of his patients. However, there is no doubt that he was also making a philanthropic, social and political gesture, by allowing poor people access to an education that had hitherto been mostly denied to them, not because of their illness, but because of their social status. Education thus occupied a special place in moral management and was part of a process of social emancipation even more than a therapeutic approach.

The “no restraint” movement at the crossroads of multiple influences and networks: from utilitarianism to Owenism

22 When he lived in Stratford-upon-Avon, John Conolly was particularly active locally in social and political life, becoming an alderman and then mayor of the town.[59] He set up a hospital and a dispensary for the poor, and “being a reformer by nature and a hearty liberal in politics, he ardently devoted himself to every measure of progress” .[60] According to his biographer, James Clark, it was at this time that he met Dr George Birkbeck, who introduced him to Lord Brougham, “the great Whig politician who was deeply involved in social improvement activities” .[61] Conolly then became involved with the Society for the Diffusion of Useful Knowledge,[62] attending their meetings and writing a few articles for their publications. He was also involved in the development of Mechanics' Institutes, to which he made a long-term commitment, including a public speech at the opening ceremony of the Mechanics' Institute in Leicester,[63] in February 1834. In this speech entitled “A Lecture on the attractions and advantages of knowledge”[64] , John Conolly declared himself “an enthusiast in the cause of popular education”.[65]

23 At the same period of his life, an opportunity arose: Conolly, through the SDUK, had remained closely linked to Lord Brougham, to whom “he entertained a great and sincere admiration”,[66] and had become close friends with Thomas Coates, the society's secretary. This had a major influence on his (short) academic career, as it is widely believed that he only gained a position as a Professor of the Practice of Medicine at University College London thanks to the “influence of Lord Brougham, one of the joint founders of the University” .[67] Suzuki considers that this position represented “a huge jump for a provincial general practitioner”,[68] and that this type of promotion would have been unthinkable without the high patronage of Lord Brougham. Edward Stern, however, qualifies the importance and prestige of the position, and recalls that “the men appointed to the fourteen initial chairs were all young and obscure, and mostly from over the border, since the emoluments were small – the total University outlay on all salaries being only £ 7,500 – and security tenuous”.[69] He also speculates that Conolly owed the position not only to Brougham but perhaps more to the support of Samuel Parr, parson of Hatton, with whom he was very close in Stratford until his death in 1825, and who was actively involved in the initial project to establish the university. After three years of teaching, Conolly relinquished his chair of medicine at the

University of London and returned to being a simple physician in the town of Warwick. In 1838, he applied for the position of medical superintendent at Hanwell Asylum. However, to his dismay, his application was rejected in favour of John Gideon Millingen's, a retired army surgeon with no knowledge whatsoever of mental illness[70]. Conolly would discover the following year that it was precisely his progressive ideas and commitment to popular education that had cost him the job.[71]

24 Following this disappointment, Conolly moved to Birmingham, to try again to establish himself as a general practitioner, with no greater success than usual, although he did manage to teach at Queen's Hospital.[72] But the position of superintendent at Hanwell, vacated prematurely by Millingen, became available again less than a year later, and this time Conolly was selected.[73]

25 In Hanwell's staff records, the official date of his employment is 2 May 1839,[74] and this date marked a real turning point in John Conolly's previously rather chaotic career.

26 What is particularly striking in the image given of him by his contemporaries is that Conolly appears to be a perfectly consensual figure, part of a respectable philanthropic movement, which seems close to the evangelical movement because his actions were endorsed by Lord Ashley, and his political opinions are regularly concealed. His religious convictions are sometimes mentioned: Conolly was a Unitarian, which is quite consistent with his commitments, as it is known that "unlike many of the new evangelical dissenters, Unitarians inherited a tradition of loyalty to the Whigs",[75] and that the humanist current that underpins Unitarianism insists on a deep belief in progress and promotes "human effort, social planning, education" and "human rights".[76] Authors such as Akihito Suzuki and Scull have noted, in hindsight, that "[Conolly's] personal belief in liberal[77] ideology played a major role [...] from the beginning of his career he had been moving in Whig and liberal circles",[78] but it is extremely rare that his contemporary biographers mention his political views. To learn more about them, it is necessary to read he testimony of Conolly's sworn enemy, Reverend Francis Tebbutt, former chaplain of Hanwell Asylum and dismissed at Conolly's request because their views were too diametrically opposed to be able to work together. Tebbutt clearly mentions Conolly's support for the Chartists[79] and his affinity with Robert Owen:

> [...] Dr. Conolly has expressed [...] his approbation of the people called Chartists, asserting that in his judgment, their political opinions are right; that they must ultimately prevail in this country; and that the government prosecutions then pending against them were tyrannical and unjust. And said Dr. Conolly did, as deponent has been informed and verily believes, some time in or about the month of June, 1839, receive at his residence in the asylum, and there entertain as his guests, Owen, the notorious founder of Socialism, and one Pare, of Birmingham, whose conduct, in consequence of his openly avowing and attempting to spread the principles and practices of Socialists, was not long since noticed by the House of Lords, and said Pare, in consequence, deprived by the government of a situation which he held under them as Registrar of births, deaths and marriages" .[80]

27 While one must be cautious about the veracity of Francis Tebbutt's statements, given his hostility to Conolly, it must be acknowledged that the reliability of the verifiable information given in the rest of his testimony, and the accuracy of the details provided about William Pare allow a certain amount of credibility to be given to his statements. It is not insignificant that John Conolly, newly appointed to Hanwell Asylum, should have chosen to invite Robert Owen and William Pare, founding member[2] of the utopian community of Queenwood.[81]

28 Even if it is very difficult to know for sure how Robert Owen and Conolly met, the most obvious lead again seems to be that of Lord Brougham, who was very close to Robert Owen as mentioned by his son, Robert Dale Owen, who emphasises the fact that Lord Brougham remained loyal to Owen until the end,[82] including the years when Owen was ostracised by the ruling classes.[83] Robert Owen's correspondence also includes a report of the annual general meeting of the Proprietors of the University of London[84] and a circular from the University concerning the medical curriculum for the year 1831-1832, [85] just after Conolly's departure. Indeed, Robert Owen, who also knew Jeremy Bentham very well from his days as his business partner in New Lanark,[86] was a shareholder of the University of London.[87] It is also possible that the link was made through Chartism, as former Owenites figured in this movement (although Owen himself was opposed to the extension of franchise), notably William Lovett ,[88] leader of the 'moral force' Chartists.[89] It is not impossible that Robert Owen also knew one of the above-mentioned asylum's magistrates, Charles Augustus Tulk, a former Whig MP, through a mutual acquaintance, Joseph Hume, “the radical People's MP”.[90]

29 For all these reasons, and given the networks shared by Conolly and Owen, Robert Owen's visit to Hanwell as reported by Reverend Tebbutt is perfectly plausible. Beyond the anecdote, it is very stimulating to analyse the impact that Owen's influence may have had on Conolly, and to identify the traces of it. Conolly's work is of interest from a therapeutic perspective, in determining the reality of non-restraint on a daily basis, and from a social perspective, in the way patients were treated and perceived as citizens, both destitute and mentally ill, but it is clear that determining the political dimension of his action, and the weight of his socialist inspiration, can only help to shed more light on the experience at Hanwell Asylum and on lunacy reform as a whole.

30 When one looks for traces of Robert Owen's influence on Conolly, assuming that Owen's visit to Conolly at Hanwell Asylum a few weeks after he took office was necessarily significant, it is undoubtedly in their relationship to education that we find them, and it is on this theme that the two men most visibly converge. Given what we know about the aims of education at Hanwell, the way lessons were conducted and the teaching practices based on pleasure, exchange and encouragement, Robert Owen's influence on Conolly's fight for education seems clearly identifiable. The innovative and respectful pedagogical practices, the permanent insistence on playfulness and enjoyment, are the most striking and singular elements of the experiment carried out, and the similarities with an Owenite conception of education are sufficiently striking to confirm Conolly's links with radicalism and Owenism. JFC Harrison considers that “few social reformers have accorded education such a central place in their philosophy as the Owenites. They spoke in lyrical terms of what could be achieved by it and attributed vast power to its influence”.[91] For them, school represents “the steam engine of the moral world”. [92] Owenites are of course deeply opposed “to the use of the whip and other coercive methods practiced by the teachers of their day”.[93] They also advocate for the opening of schools for all children and the organisation of courses for adults.[94] According to some historians, their activity represents “the most deeply rooted popular education movement of the century”.[95]

31 It is difficult to define with certainty the extent to which the mode of education at Hanwell Asylum was consciously and deliberately copied from an Owenite model, or to what extent the influence may have been more unconscious and diffuse. The profile of John Conolly, a member of the SDUK, close to Chartism, moving in liberal, radical and

Owenite circles tips the balance in favour of the former. His links with Lord Brougham further strengthen the credibility of this hypothesis, as Lord Brougham, impressed by the New Lanark school, set up a committee in London around 1818 to promote the development of a network of Infant Schools on the same model throughout the capital.[96] The founding members of this committee included one of Owen's associates, John Walker, but also Henry Hase, Lord Lansdowne, Thomas Babington and Zachary Macaulay.[97] They opened a school in 1819 in Brewers' Green, Westminster. To carry out his project, Brougham hired a teacher from New Lanark, James Buchanan, who was originally a weaver, but whom Owen had trained to become the schoolmaster in New Lanark.[98]

32 According to Akihito Suzuki, Charles Augustus Tulk, when he was at the head of the asylum's committee, designed Hanwell Asylum on the model of "the utopian factory of Robert Owen, who reportedly once came to see Conolly at the asylum".[99] That Tulk was no stranger to Robert Owen's theories and practices is not impossible, but it seems quite logical, given Conolly's intellectual and political background, that Conolly himself may have had a desire to create a form of utopian community on the New Lanark model in the asylum. Elaine Showalter also considers that "Conolly saw asylum reforms as the beginning of social reform and utopian harmony"[100] and that Owen's influence is obvious:[101]

> It is not surprising that Conolly should have found himself so much in sympathy with Owen, a paternal figure of socialist benevolence. Indeed, Conolly's utopian vision of the reformed asylum, a working community of the insane poor brought into loving harmony by the watchful ministrations of an enlightened and affectionate superintendent was similar to the vision behind Owen's experimental communities, in which the working classes were to be provided with instruments of self-improvement and self-help".[102]

33 It seems that Conolly had "found an outlet for his liberalism in creating the experimental community of Hanwell",[103] rather than extending his political activities into the outside world, or taking a more official and active stand for the Chartist movement, which he otherwise supported.

Conclusion

34 It may seem strange or too bold, even incongruous, to compare a pauper lunatic asylum (Hanwell) to a factory (New Lanark). This comparison is indeed strange if one considers the asylum as a separate structure, strictly medical and disconnected from social realities. It is much more rational when we accept the idea that the Victorian asylum is one of the ways of caring for the poor, in the same vein as the workhouse, and is part of a wider programme, governed by the Poor Law authorities. Nor could New Lanark be considered as a mere factory, but rather, as J.F.C. Harrison points out, as "a genuine attempt, even though rudimentary and clumsily paternal, at community organization"[104] The reality of an institution such as Hanwell Asylum cannot be understood without taking its medico-social dimension into account.

35 If John Conolly never publicly acknowledged the inspiration that New Lanark and Owen may have represented for him, it may have been because he found himself in charge of Hanwell Asylum at a time when Robert Owen, initially a respected upper-class philanthropist, had become much less respectable, because of his socialist, even communist theories, which were perceived as a danger by the elites.[105] Hanwell Asylum

was actually not the only mental hospital to have been designed on the New Lanark model, because a French Protestant minister by the name of John Bost,[106] influenced during his stays in Great Britain by "people who were sympathetic to Owen's thinking", [107] created in 1848, in France (in the Dordogne),[108] an institution for psychiatric care, where "everything is open onto gardens, everything is flowered as in a park. John Bost did not integrate any walls, fences or closed doors".[109] According to Michel Baron, "from the outset, we sense that John Bost's ambition was not only to take charge of the world's misery but, based on this misery, to set up a utopian place where an ideal city could be achieved".[110] That Conolly had a similar ambition at Hanwell is entirely plausible, given his political convictions and appetite for all forms of social progress. It is not surprising, however, that he was secretive about his deep-seated ambitions, for it must be remembered that John Conolly was not the sole master of Hanwell, and it is highly unlikely, if not impossible, that he would have been followed by all the magistrates if he had presented his plan for asylum reform in terms of the creation of a utopian community based on an Owenite model.[111]

36 Appearances may be deceptive, and John Conolly is often portrayed, particularly by his contemporaries, whether it be his friend and biographer Sir James Clark[112] or observers, as a consensual figure of philanthropy well integrated into the Establishment. The enthusiastic support of Lord Ashley, who constantly sang his praises and publicly defended his non-restraint methods, might suggest that Conolly's work was fully in line with the evangelical trend: evangelical reformers were involved, alongside Utilitarians, in reforms concerning asylums and the care of the mentally ill. Evangelicalism was characterised by a call to public and political action, in areas as varied as church building and Bible teaching, but also the prevention of cruelty to animals, prison reforms and the abolition of slavery.[113]As Jacques Carré points out, the evangelical movement is generally associated with the defence of the oppressed.[114] It is therefore not surprising that they should have been involved in lunacy reform. For Lord Ashley, an "evangelical aristocrat",[115] the desire for reform was not "a matter of principle, but the recognition of specific evils as a result of a keen social conscience",[116] and he himself was sometimes seen as a Benthamian utilitarian.[117] More often than not, the boundaries between utilitarianism, evangelicalism, radicalism or utopian socialism in public action were blurred, and John Conolly's figure may rightly be seen as a perfect illustration of those intertwined networks.

BIBLIOGRAPHY

Primary sources

Archives

"Hanwell Asylum Register of Officers and Servants", Hanwell Asylum Records, London Metropolitan Archives, H11/HLL/C/01/002, H11/HLL/C/01/003, H11/HLL/C/01/004

Robert Owen Correspondence Collection, National Co-operative Archives, Manchester, GB 1499 ROC/26/5/10; 1499 ROC/26/6/3;1499 ROC/26/6/12

Books and pamphlets

Cabet, Étienne, *Œuvres d'Étienne Cabet, Tome 1 : Voyage en Icarie ; Préface d'Henri Desroche* (Paris , Éditions Anthropos, 1970)

Clark, Sir James, *A Memoir of John Conolly, M.D., D.C.L., Comprising a Sketch of the Treatment of the Insane in Europe and America*, (London, John Murray, 1869)

Conolly, John, *Cottage Evenings* (London, Charles Knight, 1831)

Conolly, John, "A Lecture on the Attractions and Advantages of Knowledge: Delivered at the Opening of the Leicester Mechanics' Institute on Tuesday Evening, February 4, 1834" (Leicester, A. Cockshaw, 1834)

Conolly, John, *On the Construction and Government of Lunatic Asylums and Hospitals for the Insane* (London, John Churchill, 1847)

Esquirol, Étienne, *Aliénation mentale. Des illusions chez les aliénés. Question médico-légale sur l'isolement des aliénés* (Paris, Librairie Médicale de Crochard, 1832)

Gardiner Hill, Robert, *Total Abolition of Personal Restraint in the Treatment of the Insane. A Lecture on the Management of Lunatic Asylums, and the Treatment of the Insane; Delivered at the Mechanics' Institution, Lincoln, on the 21st of June, 1838; with Statistical Tables* (London, Simpkin, Marshall & S. Highley, 1838)

Maudsley, Henry, "Memoir of the Late John Conolly", *Journal of Mental Science*, 12 (1866)

Mill, John Stuart, *Considerations on Representative Government* (London, Parker, Son & Bourn, 1861)

Millingen, John, *Aphorisms on the Treatment and Management of the Insane with Considerations on Public and Private Lunatic Asylums, Pointing out the Errors in the Present System*, (London, Churchill, 1840)

Owen, Robert Dale, *Threading my Way: Twenty-Seven Years of Autobiography* (London, Trübner & Co, 1874)

Tebbutt, Francis, *Letter to the Magistrates of the County of Middlesex, from the Rev. Francis Tebbutt (Chaplain of the County pauper lunatic asylum, at Hanwell)* (London, John W. Parker, 1841)

Press articles

The Chartist, Sunday, 19 May 1839

The Examiner, Sunday, 19 May 1839

The Warwick Advertiser, Sunday, 19 May 1839

Secondary sources

Abel-Smith, Brian, *The Hospitals 1800-1948. A Study in Social Administration in England and Wales* (Cambridge, Mass: Harvard University Press, 1964)

Armytage, W.H.G., *Heavens Below: Utopian Experiments in England, 1560-1960* (London, Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1961)

Armytage, W.H.G., *Four Hundred Years of English Education* (Cambridge, Cambridge University Press, 1965)

Baron, Michel, *John Bost : la cité utopique* (Carrières-sous-Poissy, La Cause, 1998)

Bartlett, Peter, *The Poor Law of Lunacy: The Administration of Pauper Lunatics in Mid-Nineteenth Century England* (Leicester, Leicester University Press, 1999)

Beer, Max, *A History of British Socialism* (London, G. Bell & Sons, 1920)

Browne, William Alexander Francis, "The Moral Treatment of the Insane; a Lecture", *Journal of Mental Science*, 10 (October 1864)

Brunon-Ernst, Anne, « Introduction », *Revue d'études benthamiennes*, 19 (2021), http://journals.openedition.org/etudesbenthamiennes/8979

Charland, Louis C., "Benevolent Theory: moral Treatment at the York Retreat", *History of Psychiatry*, 18 (March 2007)

Carré, Jacques, *La Grande-Bretagne au XIXe siècle* (Paris, Hachette, « Les Fondamentaux », 1997)

Crammer, J.L., "English Asylums and English Doctors: where Scull is Wrong", *History of Psychiatry*, 5 (March 1994)

De Champs, Emmanuelle, « Utilitarisme et liberté » and « Religion, politique et utilité chez Jeremy Bentham », *Archives de Philosophie*, 78 (2015), pp. 221-228 and 275-290

Digby, Anne, *Madness, Morality and Medicine: A Study of the York Retreat 1796-1914* (Cambridge, Cambridge University Press, 1985)

Donnelly, Michael, *Managing the Mind: A Study of Medical Psychology in Early Nineteenth-century Britain* (London, Tavistock Publications, 1983)

Dubois, Laurence, *L'Asile de Hanwell : un modèle utopique dans l'histoire de la psychiatrie anglaise ?* (Paris, Presses de la Sorbonne Nouvelle, 2017)

Dolléans, Édouard, *Robert Owen, 1771-1858 : individualisme et socialisme* (Paris, F. Alcan, 1907)

Foucault, Michel, *Histoire de la folie à l'âge classique* (Paris, Gallimard, 1972)

Gardner, James, *Sweet Bells Jangled Out of Tune: A History of the Sussex Lunatic Asylum (St Francis Hospital, Haywards Heath)* (Brighton, published by the author, 1999)

Harrison, J.F.C., *Learning and Living, 1790 – 1960, A Study in the History of the English Adult Education Movement* (London, Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1961)

Harrison, J.F.C., *Utopianism and Education: Robert Owen and the Owenites* (New York, Teachers College Press, Columbia University, 1968)

Harrison, J.F.C., *Robert Owen and the Owenites in Britain and America: The Quest for the New Moral World* (London, Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1969)

Hewett, Philip, *Understanding Unitarians* (London, Hibbert Trust, 1992)

Harvey, Rowland Hill, *Robert Owen, Social Idealist* (Berkeley, University of California Press, 1949)

Hodgkinson, Ruth G., *The Origins of the National Health Service. The Medical Services of the New Poor Law 1834-1871* (London, Wellcome Historical Medical Library, 1967)

Hunter, Richard, "One Hundred years after John Conolly", *Proceedings of the Royal Society of Medicine*, 60 (January 1967)

Jones, Dorsey D., "Edwin Chadwick and the Early Public Health Movement in England", *University of Iowa Studies in the Social Sciences*, 10, 3, (1931)

Jones, Kathleen, *Mental Health and Social Policy, 1845-1959* (London, Routledge, 1960)

Jones, Kathleen, *Lunacy, Law and Conscience, 1744-1845: The Social History of the Care of the Insane* (London, Routledge, 1998)

Llewellyn Woodward, Ernest, *The Age of Reform (1815-170), Oxford History of England*, vol. 1 (Oxford, Oxford University Press, 1962)

Lawson, John and Harold Silver, *A Social History of Education in England*, (London and New York, Routledge, 2007)

Leigh, Denis, *The Historical Development of British Psychiatry, Volume 1, 18th and 19th Century* (Oxford, London, New York and Paris, Pergamon Press, 1961)

Midwinter, Eric, *Victorian Social Reform* (London, Longman, 1968)

Miller, Edgar, "Variations in the Official Prevalence and Disposal of the Insane in England Under the Poor Law, 1850-1900", *History of Psychiatry*, 18 (March 2007)

Morton, Arthur Leslie, *The Life and Ideas of Robert Owen* (London, Lawrence & Wishart, 1962)

Oppenheim, Janet, *Shattered Nerves: Doctors, Patients and Depression in Victorian England* (New York and Oxford, Oxford University Press, 1991)

Podmore, Frank, *Robert Owen: a Biography*, 1 (London, Hutchinson & Co, 1906)

Roberts, Andrew, *Mental Health Timeline*, *A Middlesex University Resource*, http://studymore.org.uk/mhhtim.htm (Middlesex University, 2001)

Sangster, Paul, *Pity My Simplicity: The Evangelical Revival and the Religious Education of Children, 1738-1800* (London, Epworth Press, 1963)

Scull, Andrew, "Moral Treatment Reconsidered: Some Sociological Comments on an Episode in the History of British Psychiatry", *Psychological Medicine*, 9, 3 (July 1979)

Scull, Andrew (ed.), *Madhouses, Mad Doctors and Madmen. Social History of Psychiatry in the Victorian Era* (Philadelphia, University of Pennsylvania, 1981)

Scull, Andrew, "A Brilliant Career? John Conolly and Victorian Psychiatry", *Victorian Studies,* 27, 2 (1983-84)

Scull, Andrew, *Social Order/Mental Disorder: Anglo-American Psychiatry in Historical Perspective*, chapter 7, "John Conolly: A Victorian Psychiatric Career" (Berkeley, University of California Press, 1989)

Scull, Andrew, *The Most Solitary of Afflictions: Madness and Society in Britain, 1700-1900* (New Haven and London, Yale University Press, 1993)

Seed, John, *The Role of Unitarianism in the Formation of Liberal Culture, 1775-1851: A Social History* (Hull, University of Hull, 1981)

Showalter, Elaine, *The Female Malady. Women, Madness and English Culture, 1830-1980* (London, Virago Press, 1987)

Siméon, Ophélie, *Robert Owen's Experiment at New Lanark. From Paternalism to Socialism* (Cham, Switzerland, Palgrave Macmillan, 2017)

Skultans, Vieda, *Madness and Morals: Ideas on Insanity in the Nineteenth Century* (1975) (London, Boston, Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1979)

Smith, Roger, *Trial by Medicine: Insanity and Responsibility in Victorian Trials* (Edinburgh, Edinburgh University Press, 1981)

Stern, Edward S., "Three Nineteenth-Century Psychiatrists of Warwickshire", *Journal of Mental Science*, 107 (March 1961)

Suzuki, Akihito, "The Politics and Ideology of Non-Restraint: The Case of the Hanwell Asylum", *Medical History*, 39 (1995)

Suzuki, Akihito, *Madness at Home: The Psychiatrist, the Patient and the Family in England, 1820-1860* (Berkeley and London, University of California Press, 2006)

Thompson, F.M.L., *The Rise of Respectable Society: A Social History of Victorian Britain*, *1830-1900,* (Cambridge, Massachusetts, Harvard University Press, 1988)

Thompson, F.M.L. (ed.), *The Cambridge Social History of Britain, 1750-1950*, vol. 3, *Social Agencies and Institutions* (Cambridge, Cambridge University Press, 1990)

Tuke, Daniel Hack, *Chapters in the History of the Insane in the British Isles* (London, Kegan Paul & Co., 1882)

Turner, Trevor Howard, "Rich and Mad in Victorian England", *Lectures on the History of Psychiatry* (London, Gaskell, 1990)

Wardle, David, *English Popular Education 1780-1870* (Cambridge, Cambridge University Press, 1970)

Wood, Laura Christine, "John Conolly and the Historical Interpretation of Moral Management," Master's dissertation in History (Vancouver, University of British Columbia, 1985), http://circle.ubc.ca/handle/2429/26633

Wright, David, "The Certification of Insanity in Nineteenth-century England and Wales", *History of Psychiatry*, 9 (September 1998)

Yorston, Graeme, and Camilla Haw, "Old and Mad in Victorian Oxford: a Study of Patients Aged 60 and Over Admitted to the Warneford and Littlemore Asylums in the Nineteenth Century", *History of Psychiatry*, 16 (December 2005)

NOTES

1. Brunon-Ernst, Anne, « Introduction », *Revue d'études benthamiennes*, 19 (2021), http://journals.openedition.org/etudesbenthamiennes/8979.

2. De Champs, Emmanuelle, « Utilitarisme et liberté » and « Religion, politique et utilité chez Jeremy Bentham », *Archives de Philosophie*, 78 (2015), pp. 221-228 and 275-290; Jones, Dorsey D., "Edwin Chadwick and the Early Public Health Movement in England", *University of Iowa Studies in the Social Sciences*, 10, 3 (1931); Llewellyn Woodward, Ernest, *The Age of Reform (1815-170), Oxford History of England*, vol. 1 (Oxford, Oxford University Press, 1962); Midwinter, Eric, *Victorian Social Reform* (London, Longman, 1968).

3. Robert Owen, who was an industrialist, set out to make his cotton mill of New Lanark (in Scotland) an experiment in philanthropic management. Owen believed that a person's character is formed by the effects of their environment. He was thus convinced that if he created the right environment, he could produce rational, good and humane people. He owned the New Lanark factory from 1800 to 1825 and it became a model factory (with visitors coming from all over the world) under his supervision.

4. Siméon, Ophélie, *Robert Owen's Experiment at New Lanark. From Paternalism to Socialism* (Cham, Switzerland, Palgrave Macmillan, 2017).

5. Jones, Kathleen, *Mental Health and Social Policy, 1845-1959* (London, Routledge, 1960); *Lunacy, Law and Conscience, 1744-1845: The Social History of the Care of the Insane* (London, Routledge, 1998).

6. Foucault, Michel, *Histoire de la folie à l'âge classique* (Paris, Gallimard, 1972).
7. Scull, Andrew, "Moral Treatment Reconsidered: Some Sociological Comments on an Episode in the History of British Psychiatry", *Psychological Medicine*, 9, 3 (July 1979), pp. 421-428; *The Most Solitary of Afflictions: Madness and Society in Britain, 1700-1900* (New Haven and London, Yale University Press, 1993).
8. Smith, Roger, *Trial by Medicine: Insanity and Responsibility in Victorian Trials* (Edinburgh, Edinburgh University Press, 1981).
9. Bartlett, Peter, *The Poor Law of Lunacy: The Administration of Pauper Lunatics in Mid-Nineteenth Century England* (Leicester, Leicester University Press, 1999).
10. Yorston, Graeme, and Camilla Haw, "Old and Mad in Victorian Oxford: a Study of Patients Aged 60 and Over Admitted to the Warneford and Littlemore Asylums in the Nineteenth Century", *History of Psychiatry*, 16 (December 2005), pp. 395-396.
11. Bartlett, Peter, *The Poor Law of Lunacy,* pp. 1-7.
12. Gardner, James, *Sweet Bells Jangled Out of Tune: A History of the Sussex Lunatic Asylum (St Francis Hospital, Haywards Heath)* (Brighton, published by the author, 1999), p. 7.
13. Hodgkinson, Ruth G., *The Origins of the National Health Service. The Medical Services of the New Poor Law 1834-1871* (London, Wellcome Historical Medical Library, 1967), p. 182.
14. Turner, Trevor Howard, "Rich and Mad in Victorian England", *Lectures on the History of Psychiatry* (London, Gaskell, 1990), p. 171.
15. *Ibid.*
16. Anthony Ashley-Cooper, 7th Earl of Shaftesbury (1801-1885). He became Lord Shaftesbury in 1851, the name by which he is known today. I will refer to him as 'Lord Ashley' in this study to avoid any anachronism, since this is how he appears in all the documents of my period of reference. It is interesting to note that Lord Ashley has rightly been remembered as a great philanthropist, particularly for his work on behalf of education and the regulation of child labour, but that his work on behalf of the insane is not systematically mentioned, even though it was a struggle he waged with fervour until his death. It is not mentioned, for example, in Roland Marx's biographical note on him in the *Encyclopaedia Universalis*.
17. Jones, K., *Lunacy, Law and Conscience,* p. 135.
18. Esquirol, Étienne, *Aliénation mentale. Des illusions chez les aliénés. Question médico-légale sur l'isolement des aliénés* (Paris, Librairie Médicale de Crochard, 1832), p. 32.
19. Gardiner Hill, Robert, *Total Abolition of Personal Restraint in the Treatment of the Insane. A Lecture on the Management of Lunatic Asylums, and the Treatment of the Insane ; Delivered at the Mechanics' Institution, Lincoln, on the 21st of June, 1838 ; with Statistical Tables* (London, Simpkin, Marshall & S. Highley, 1838), *p.* 55.
20. Showalter, Elaine, *The Female Malady. Women, Madness and English Culture, 1830-1980* (London, Virago Press, 1987), p. 25.
21. Jones, K., *Lunacy, Law and Conscience,* p. ix.
22. Crammer, J.L., "English Asylums and English Doctors: Where Scull is Wrong", *History of Psychiatry*, 5 (March 1994), p. 110. The figure given by Peter Bartlett is very similar : according to him, there were 3,829 lunatics in workhouses in 1844, and this figure reached 17,825 in 1890. Bartlett, Peter, *The Poor Law of Lunacy*, p. 44.
23. Miller, Edgar, "Variations in the Official Prevalence and Disposal of the Insane in England Under the Poor Law, 1850-1900", *History of Psychiatry*, 18 (March 2007), p. 32. This difference in cost disappeared in 1874, when a system of subsidies was introduced, with 4 shillings per patient per week being paid to the public asylum, i.e., about 40 % of the total cost (but not by the Poor Law authorities).
24. Wright, David, "The Certification of Insanity in Nineteenth-century England and Wales", *History of Psychiatry*, 9 (September 1998), p. 269
25. Hodgkinson, Ruth G., *The Origins of the National Health Service*, p. 3.

26. Abel-Smith, Brian, *The Hospitals 1800-1948. A Study in Social Administration in England and Wales* (Cambridge, Mass. : Harvard University Press, 1964), pp. 46-47.
27. Article 27 of the *Poor Law*, *in* Roberts, Andrew, *Mental Health Timeline, A Middlesex University Resource*, http://studymore.org.uk/mhhtim.htm, Middlesex University, 2001.
28. Article 45, *Ibid*.
29. Bynum, William F., "Rationales for Therapy in British Psychiatry", in Scull, A. (ed.), *Madhouses, Mad Doctors and Madmen*, p. 37.
30. Browne, William Alexander Francis, "The Moral Treatment of the Insane; a Lecture", *Journal of Mental Science*, 10 (October 1864) p. 312.
31. *Ibid.*, p. 313.
32. Oppenheim, J., *Shattered Nerves, p.* 23.
33. Skultans, Vieda, *Madness and Morals: Ideas on Insanity in the Nineteenth Century* (London, Boston, Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1979), p. 17 In his highly popular book *Self-Help*, published in 1859, Samuel Smiles extolled the values of effort and hard work, and the idea that each person is the master of their own destiny through sheer force of will.
34. Charland, Louis C., "Benevolent Theory: Moral Treatment at the York Retreat", *History of Psychiatry*, 18 (March 2007), p. 63. Here the author opposes the theories of Michel Foucault, who views the experience at the Retreat solely in terms of oppression and the internalisation of constraint, and states that "both Foucault's historical interpretation and philosophical evaluation of moral treatment at the Retreat appear to be seriously off the mark".
35. Bynum, W. F., "Rationales for Therapy in British Psychiatry", p. 37.
36. Clark, Sir James, *A Memoir of John Conolly, M.D., D.C.L., Comprising a Sketch of the Treatment of the Insane in Europe and America*, (London, John Murray, 1869), p. 4.
37. Tuke, Daniel Hack, *Chapters in the History of the Insane in the British Isles* (London, Kegan Paul & Co., 1882), p. 204.
38. For an in-depth study of Hanwell Asylum, see Dubois, Laurence, *L'Asile de Hanwell : un modèle utopique dans l'histoire de la psychiatrie anglaise ?* (Paris, Presses de la Sorbonne Nouvelle, 2017).
39. Walton, John, "The Treatment of Pauper Lunatics in Victorian England: The Case of Lancaster Asylum, 1816-1870", *in* Scull, Andrew (ed.), *Madhouses, Mad Doctors and Madmen, p.* 167.
40. An approach to treating mental illness in the 19th century influenced by humanism and a belief that a rational, caring approach would enable patients to normalize their thoughts and actions. Also called "moral treatment".
41. Suzuki, Akihito, "The Politics and Ideology of Non-Restraint: The Case of the Hanwell Asylum", *Medical History,* 39 (1995), p. 2.
42. *Ibid.*
43. *Ibid.*, pp. 2, 5-6.
44. *Ibid.*, p. 6.
45. *Ibid,* pp. 2, 5-6.
46. Tebbutt, Francis, *Letter to the Magistrates of the County of Middlesex, from the Rev. Francis Tebbutt (Chaplain of the County Pauper Lunatic Asylum, at Hanwell)* (London, John W. Parker, 1841), p. 27.
47. Suzuki, A., "The Politics and Ideology of Non-Restraint", p. 10.
48. Tebbutt, F., *Letter to the Magistrates, p.* 27.
49. Suzuki, A., "The Politics and Ideology of Non-Restraint", p. 7.
50. A society founded in 1810 for the purpose of translating into English, publishing and publicising the work of Emmanuel Swedenborg (1688-1772), a Swedish scientist, philosopher, theologian and theosophist. This organisation still exists today.
51. Suzuki, A., "The Politics and Ideology of Non-Restraint", p. 8.
52. *Ibid.*, pp. 3 and 17.
53. Lawson, John, and Harold Silver, *A Social History of Education in England*, (London and New York, Routledge, 2007), p. 283.

54. Sutherland, Gillian, *in* Thompson, F.M.L. (ed.), *The Cambridge Social History of Britain, 1750-1950, vol.* 3, *Social Agencies and Institutions* (Cambridge, Cambridge University Press, 1990), p. 129.
55. Sangster, Paul, *Pity My Simplicity: The Evangelical Revival and the Religious Education of Children, 1738-1800* (London, Epworth Press, 1963), p. 54.
56. Armytage, W.H.G., *Four Hundred Years of English Education* (Cambridge, Cambridge University Press, 1965), p. 101.
57. Wardle, David, *English Popular Education 1780-1870* (Cambridge, Cambridge University Press, 1970), pp. 125-126.
58. Conolly, John, "A Lecture on the Attractions and Advantages of Knowledge: Delivered at the opening of the Leicester Mechanics' Institute on Tuesday Evening, February 4, 1834" (Leicester, A. Cockshaw, 1834), p. 32. In this, Conolly anticipated John Stuart Mill, who stated that "universal education must precede universal suffrage". Mill, John Stuart, *Considerations on Representative Government* (London, Parker, Son & Bourn, 1861).
59. Clark, Sir J., *A Memoir of John Conolly*, p. 4.
60. Remarks by his son-in-law, Henry Maudsley, himself a psychiatrist, in 1866, when Conolly died, quoted in Hunter, Richard, "One Hundred Years after John Conolly", *Proceedings of the Royal Society of Medicine*, 60 (January 1967), p. 86. Henry Maudsley married Conolly's youngest daughter, Anne Caroline, in January 1866. He was thus in contact with Conolly at the end of his life.
61. Wood, Laura Christine, "John Conolly and the Historical Interpretation of Moral Management," Master's dissertation in History (Vancouver, University of British Columbia, 1985), http://circle.ubc.ca/handle/2429/26633, p. 62.
62. Founded in 1826 by Lord Brougham, the aim of this organisation was to publish popular scientific or literary works for the use of the working classes, to develop a taste for reading and to inculcate basic scientific notions in all citizens, in particular those who had no access to education.
63. A Mechanics' Institute whose creation also seems to have been supported by the Unitarian Chapel of Leicester, which gave Conolly, being a Unitarian himself, an additional reason to take part in its inauguration.
64. Conolly, J., "A Lecture on the Attractions and Advantages of Knowledge", p. 32
65. *Ibid*, p. 5
66. Maudsley, Henry, "Memoir of the late John Conolly", *Journal of Mental Science*, 12 (1866) p. 166.
67. Stern, Edward S., "Three Nineteenth-Century Psychiatrists of Warwickshire", *Journal of Mental Science*, 107 (March 1961), p. 187. Although Bentham played no direct part in the establishment of UCL, many of the founders, particularly James Mill (1773-1836) and Henry Brougham (1778-1868), held him in high esteem, and their project embodied many of his ideas on education and society.
68. Suzuki, Akihito, *Madness at Home: The Psychiatrist, the Patient and the Family in England, 1820-1860* (Berkeley and London, University of California Press, 2006), p. 75.
69. Stern, E.S., "Three Nineteenth-Century Psychiatrists of Warwickshire", pp. 187-188.
70. Scull, A., *Social Order/ Mental Disorder, p.* 186. However, after leaving Hanwell, John Millingen published a book entitled *Aphorisms on the Treatment and Management of the Insane with Considerations on Public and Private Lunatic Asylums, pointing out the Errors in the present System*, (London, Churchill, 1840).
71. Letter from John Conolly to Thomas Coates, dated 26 August 1839, Society for the Diffusion of Knowledge Archives, University of London Library, quoted by Scull, Andrew, "A Brilliant Career? John Conolly and Victorian Psychiatry", *Victorian Studies,* 27, 2 (1983-84), n° 2, *p.* 216. In this letter Conolly expressed his refusal to attend an SDUK conference in Lewes. Despite what he said at the time, probably out of spite, John Conolly continued to work for the education of the working classes at Hanwell Asylum.
72. Stern, E.S., "Three Nineteenth-Century Psychiatrists of Warwickshire", p. 188.
73. *The Warwick Advertiser*, *The Examiner* and *The Chartist*, Sunday, 19 May 1839.

74. "Hanwell Asylum Register of Officers and Servants", Hanwell Asylum Records, London Metropolitan Archives, H11/HLL/C/01/002, H11/HLL/C/01/003, H11/HLL/C/01/004.

75. Seed, John, *The Role of Unitarianism in the Formation of Liberal Culture, 1775-1851: A Social History* (Hull, University of Hull, 1981), p. 364.

76. Hewett, Philip, *Understanding Unitarians* (London, Hibbert Trust, 1992), p. 7. Many Victorian reformers were Unitarians : Charles Booth, Harriet Martineau, Jeremy Bentham among others ; Robert Owen was also close to the Unitarian movement, at least during his younger years as a Manchester mill-manager :"My father, a Deist, or free-thinking Unitarian[...]". Owen, Robert Dale, *Threading my Way : Twenty-Seven Years of Autobiography* (London, Trübner & Co, 1874), p. 76.

77. The term, which can be confusing, especially in French, is to be taken here in the sense of "favourable to individual liberties, in the political, economic and social field" (definition translated from the *Petit Robert de la langue française*) but even more so as "favourable to progress and change, socially as well as politically and religiously" (*Oxford Advanced Learner's Dictionary*).

78. Suzuki, A., *Madness at Home*, p. 75.

79. Chartism was a political and social movement that developed throughout the country from 1837 to 1848 and took its name from the fact that its primary demand, the reform of Parliament, was detailed in a six-point charter, which included the demand for the right to vote for all men, a parliamentary allowance for MPs, a secret ballot and the annual renewal of Parliament. Despite the 1.2 million signatures collected - a considerable number for the time - Parliament rejected it in 1839.

80. Tebbutt, F., *Letter to the Magistrates,* pp. 18-19.

81. Queenwood (1839-1845) was the only British intentional community established with Robert Owen's endorsement.

82. Owen, R. D., *Threading my Way, p.* 198.

83. *Ibid.*

84. Report of the Annual General Meeting of the Proprietors of the University of London (23 Feb 1831), Robert Owen Correspondence Collection, National Co-operative Archives, Manchester, GB 1499 ROC/26/6/3.

85. Circulars for the University of London, Medical courses available at the university for the year 1831-32 (5 Sept 1831), Robert Owen Correspondence Collection, National Co-operative Archives, Manchester, GB 1499 ROC/26/6/12.

86. Owen, R.D. *Threading my Way*, p. 198.

87. Receipt for shares in the University of London, £ 50 single shares in the University of London: one each in the names of Robert Owen, Robert Dale Owen and William Owen (6 April 1830), Robert Owen Correspondence Collection, National Co-operative Archives, Manchester, GB 1499 ROC/26/5/10.

88. William Lovett (1800-1877), co-author of the People's Charter, representative of the 'moral force' trend of Chartism. He was sentenced to imprisonment in 1839 for libel and treated as a criminal. Max Beer considers that his sufferings at the time were nothing compared to the attacks he had to endure from the leader of the 'physical force' of Chartism, Feargus O'Connor. During his year of imprisonment, he developed a plan to establish a nationwide system of popular education. Beer, Max, *A History of British Socialism* (London, G. Bell & Sons, 1920), pp. 4-6.

89. Dolléans, Édouard, *Robert Owen, 1771-1858 : individualisme et socialisme* (Paris, F. Alcan, 1907), p. 321.

90. Suzuki, A., "The Politics and Ideology of Non-Restraint", p. 7; Owen, R.D., *Threading my Way, p.* 192. Charles Augustus Tulk was also a proprietor of the University of London.

91. Harrison, J.F.C., *Utopianism and Education: Robert Owen and the Owenites* (New York, Teachers College Press, Columbia University, 1968), p. 27.

92. Harrison, J.F.C., *Robert Owen and the Owenites in Britain and America: The Quest for the New Moral World* (London, Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1969), p. 147. J.F.C. Harrison quotes from George Mudie,

born in 1788, a famous Owenite in his time, author of a dozen books and an active member of the early Orbiston community (founded by Abram Combe in 1825).

93. Harvey, Rowland Hill, *Robert Owen, Social Idealist* (Berkeley, University of California Press, 1949), p. 126.

94. This concern for adult education is commonly found in socialist projects for society, notably in Étienne Cabet, who was strongly inspired by Owen, and for whom "Andragogy", or the active pedagogy of adults, is the greatest weapon against the use of violence". Cabet, Étienne, *Œuvres d'Étienne Cabet, Tome 1 : Voyage en Icarie ; Préface d'Henri Desroche* (Paris, Éditions Anthropos,1970), p. lix.

95. Lawson, J., and H. Silver, *A Social History of Education in England*, p. 292.

96. Owen, R.D., *Threading my Way,* pp. 114-115.

97. Podmore, Frank, *Robert Owen: a Biography* (London, Hutchinson & Co, 1906, vol. 1), p. 159.

98. Owen, R.D., *Threading my Way*, p. 114.

99. Suzuki, A., "The Politics and Ideology of Non-Restraint", p. 13.

100. Showalter, E., *The Female Malady,* p. 112.

101. *Ibid*., p. 45.

102. *Ibid*., pp. 45-46. Showalter also notes that in 1843, a few years after Conolly's arrival, an Owenite community called 'Moreville Communitorium' was established in the village of Hanwell by John Goodwyn Barmby and Catherine Barmby (née Reynolds). The experiment did not last more than a year. Goodwyn Barmby, also a Chartist and founder of the first Communist Church was influenced by the French socialists (Cabet in particular) ; he later became a Unitarian minister in Wakefield, Yorkshire, where he supported the town's Mechanics' Institute. Harrison, J.F.C., *Learning and living, 1790 – 1960, A Study in the History of the English Adult Education Movement* (London, Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1961), p. 117. For a presentation of the Hanwell community (Hanwell /Moreville Communitorium) see Armytage, W.H.G., *Heavens Below : Utopian Experiments in England, 1560-1960* (London, Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1961), pp. 196-208.

103. Showalter, E., *The Female Malady*, p. 46.

104. Harrison, J.F.C., *Utopianism and Education: Robert Owen and the Owenites,* p. 156.

105. Morton, Arthur Leslie, *The Life and Ideas of Robert Owen* (London, Lawrence & Wishart, 1962), p. 26.

106. John Bost, 1817-1881. His real (French) name was Jean, but as he spent much of his time in England, and as 'Jean" is a feminine name in English, he ended up being called John.

107. Baron, Michel, *John Bost : la cité utopique* (Carrières-sous-Poissy, La Cause, 1998), p. 43.

108. The institution was created in the village of La Force. The asylum founded by Bost, "La Famille", took in young orphan girls. It was the first of a long series of asylums run by what was to become the Bost Foundation, which was recognised as a public utility in 1877 and is still in operation today, caring for patients at 38 different sites in 4 regions of France in 2022.

109. Baron, M., *John Bost : la cité utopique*, p. 31

110. *Ibid*., p. 9.

111. It can be assumed, without certainty (even if this is the thesis supported by Suzuki), that Charles Augustus Tulk could have been in favour of it, being himself a former Whig MP and close to the radicals; it seems very unlikely, however, that John Adams, a Tory, albeit a very enlightened one, could have adhered to this ideal, and it is even more unlikely that the rest of the magistrates had Owenite sympathies.

112. Sir James Clark, 1788-1870, physician to Queen Victoria from 1837 to 1860.

113. Thompson, F.M.L., *The Rise of Respectable Society: A Social History of Victorian Britain*, *1830-1900,* (Cambridge, Massachusetts, Harvard University Press), 1988, p. 250.

114. Carré, Jacques, *La Grande-Bretagne au XIXe siècle* (Paris, Hachette, « Les Fondamentaux », 1997), p. 115.

115. Dawson, Christopher, "The Humanitarians", *in* Grisewood, Harman, Trevelyan, G.M., Russel, Bertrand et al., *Ideas and Beliefs of the Victorians: An Historic Revaluation of the Victorian Age.* (New York, E.P. Dutton & Co, 1966), p. 249.
116. Jones, Dorsey D., *Edwin Chadwick and the Early Public Health Movement*, p. 61.
117. *Ibid.*

ABSTRACTS

An in-depth reform of the asylum system took place in Great Britain from the 1830s onwards, under the influence of Dr John Conolly, who succeeded in imposing a new model at Hanwell pauper lunatic asylum, near London, a model that was more respectful of the patients and based on the abandonment of mechanical restraint (non-restraint) combined with occupational therapy. The success of this system at Hanwell, the largest asylum in the country with over a thousand inmates, contributed to the spread of what became a form of psychiatric orthodoxy for the next thirty years. Far from being a strictly medical measure, this reform was anchored in a general reform of poor relief. In this respect, it was in line with the Poor Law of 1834 (inspired by Jeremy Bentham, notably under the aegis of Edwin Chadwick, secretary of the Poor Law Commission). This reform was also part of a more political reflection on the extension of civil and social rights for the working classes, in particular under the impetus of John Conolly: his personality and his political commitments, in favour of Chartism, his participation in popular education movements such as the Society for the Diffusion of Useful Knowledge, and his links with Lord Brougham and Robert Owen make him a particularly representative figure of the reformers of the time, moving in complementary circles with porous boundaries. This study thus sets out to demonstrate the combined influence of utilitarianism and utopian socialism on lunacy reform and its implementation at Hanwell Asylum.

Une réforme profonde du système asilaire s'opère en Grande-Bretagne à partir des années 1830, sous l'influence du docteur John Conolly qui parvient à imposer à l'asile pour aliénés indigents de Hanwell, près de Londres, un nouveau modèle, plus respectueux des patients et fondé sur un abandon des moyens de contention mécanique associé à une thérapie occupationnelle. La réussite de ce système à l'échelle de Hanwell, le plus grand asile du pays, qui abrite plus de mille pensionnaires, contribue à la diffusion de ce qui devient une forme d'orthodoxie psychiatrique pour les trente années à venir. Loin d'être une mesure strictement médicale, cette réforme est ancrée dans une réforme globale du système public d'assistance aux pauvres. Elle rejoint en cela la *Poor Law* de 1834, d'inspiration Benthamienne (notamment sous l'égide d'Edwin Chadwick, secrétaire de la *Poor Law Commission*). Cette réforme s'inscrit également dans une réflexion plus politique d'extension des droits civiques et sociaux des classes populaires, en particulier sous l'impulsion de John Conolly : sa personnalité et ses engagements politiques, en faveur du Chartisme notamment, son appartenance à des mouvements d'éducation populaire tels que la « *Society for the Diffusion of Useful Knowledge* », ses liens avec Lord Brougham et Robert Owen font de lui une figure particulièrement représentative des réformateurs de l'époque, se mouvant dans des cercles complémentaires aux frontières poreuses. Cette étude s'attache ainsi à démontrer l'influence mêlée de l'utilitarisme et du socialisme utopique sur la réforme des asiles et sa mise en place à l'asile de Hanwell.

INDEX

Keywords: owenism, utilitarianism, lunacy reform, Poor Law, Victorian asylum, no restraint, popular education, chartism
Mots-clés: owénisme, utilitarisme, réforme du système asilaire, assistance aux pauvres, asile victorien, abandon des moyens de contention mécanique, éducation populaire, chartisme

AUTHOR

LAURENCE DUBOIS

CREA (Centre de Recherches Anglophones), Université Paris Nanterre